



Fundamentals of Human Resource Management (HRM1)

Module 7: Job Analysis, Design and Evaluation

Lesson 2: Job Design

Lesson Notes

KMVTECHUG

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What Is Job Design, and What Makes a Design Good

Job design is the way a set of tasks, or an entire job, is organised. It determines what tasks are done, how they are done, how many are done in a given time, and in what order. It is an ongoing process, adjusted as workplace conditions and tasks change, and organisations increasingly see it as essential, since poor job design tends to increase employee turnover and boredom.

The concept traces back to early management thinkers such as Frederick Taylor, who believed standardised, organised work increased both worker morale and organisational efficiency (Taylor, 1911). Modern job design has moved well beyond pure standardisation, but the underlying insight remains: how a job is structured directly affects how well, and how willingly, people perform it.

Good job design involves administrative choices about what an employee does, for how long, where, and when, giving employees choice wherever realistically possible. It takes into account all factors affecting the work, organising tasks so the whole job is less likely to pose a risk to the employee, and considers both physical characteristics, such as the muscular energy required and appropriate rest schedules, and mental characteristics, such as whether the work is monotonous or genuinely demanding.

Good job design also allows for employee input, since employees generally understand their own jobs better than anyone else, provides adequate rest schedules, and gives employees clear feedback about their performance.

A Ugandan call centre that has agents answer calls continuously for eight hours with no scheduled breaks is practising poor job design, regardless of how well trained those agents are, since the design itself ignores basic mental fatigue.

Reflect: Think of a repetitive job you have observed or experienced. What single change to its design, more variety, better rest breaks, clearer feedback, would have improved it the most?

Approaches to Job Design

Job enlargement changes a job to include more or different tasks, expanding it horizontally. It adds interest to the work but does not necessarily add responsibility. For example, instead of only sorting mail for each department, a mailroom assistant might also personally deliver the mail to each department, adding variety without adding authority.

Job rotation moves employees between different tasks, distributing work across a group. When an activity is no longer challenging, the employee rotates to a different job at the same level requiring similar skills. Management generally believes job rotation helps cut turnover and reduce boredom by diversifying employee activity.

Job enrichment allows employees to take on more responsibility, accountability, and independence, expanding a job vertically rather than horizontally. It increases the degree to which a worker controls the planning and evaluation of their own work, giving employees the freedom to assess and correct their own performance rather than waiting for a supervisor to do so.

Autonomous work teams, also called self-managed work teams, apply job enrichment at group level. The team itself is free to determine how assigned goals will be accomplished and how tasks are allocated among members, rather than a supervisor dictating every detail.

A Ugandan textile factory considering how to reduce high turnover among machine operators might start with job rotation, moving operators between different machines to reduce monotony, before eventually considering job enrichment, giving experienced operators responsibility for quality checks on their own output.

Reflect: *Of job enlargement, job rotation, job enrichment, and autonomous work teams, which do you think would be easiest for a small Ugandan organisation to implement with limited resources, and which would be hardest?*

Why Job Design Matters

Well designed jobs deliver measurable benefits. Increasing task variety alleviates boredom and avoids excessive static body positions or repetitive movements, by varying body position, muscles used, and mental activity required. Promoting regular rest breaks helps address the strain of repetitive movement or static posture, and employees generally prefer frequent shorter breaks over fewer long ones. Good job design also makes training clearer and more focused, since correct procedures and expectations are identified as part of the design process itself, rather than figured out informally after the fact.

Perhaps most importantly, good job design contributes directly to job satisfaction. Employees derive both intrinsic and extrinsic satisfaction from performing a variety of meaningful tasks, and the feedback an employee receives about their work, combined with a genuine sense that their abilities are being used well, contributes significantly to how satisfied they feel in their role.

The next lesson moves from designing jobs to evaluating them, determining not how a job should be structured, but how much that job is actually worth relative to every other job in the organisation.